



3rd

2014, So close, yet so far: Brazil 2014 brought Messi agonisingly close to the prize that had begun to define his international story. He carried Argentina through a memorable campaign, won the Golden Ball and reached the final, only for Mario Gotze's extra-time strike to hand Germany the trophy. The dream was within touching distance, but heartbreak had the final word. GETTY IMAGES



4th

2021, The weight lifted: For years, international glory had remained the one glaring omission from Messi's extraordinary resume. Then came the heroics at the Maracana. Argentina beat Brazil 1-0 in the 2021 Copa America final, finally ending its 28-year wait for a major senior international trophy. For Messi, it was more than silverware. It was a weight finally lifted.

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